IT Project Management 1CWK40

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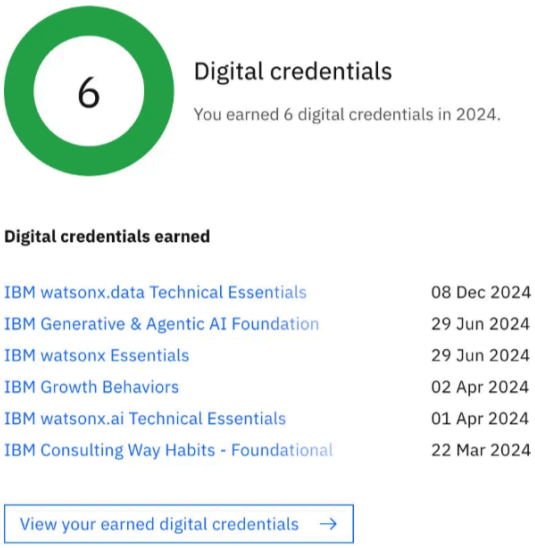
Project Context

IBM is a multinational technology company who specialise in hybrid cloud, artificial intelligence, and consulting services with our primary goal of bringing success to our clients and partners. (IBM,2025) IBM create partnerships through collaborative agreements between multiple organisations that work together to achieve specific goals while maintaining allowing them to maintain their independence. (Piseddu, 2024) An example of this strategy is IBM's partnering with UK Public Sector, holding a partnership with BAE Systems. We insert our consultants, values and expertises into BAE Systems in order to advise, design and build business innovation that matters. (IBM,2025) Exercising these values

Image from IBM Recognition Center: "Client and Partner Success Award."

resulting in being nominated and awarded the Client and Partner Success Award for my expertise through a Production Deployment Go Live.



Images from IBM YourLearning Platform: "Achieved Top 7% Champion Learner Gold through continuous learning achieved 6 digital credentials focusing on Consulting Habits and Growth Behaviours."

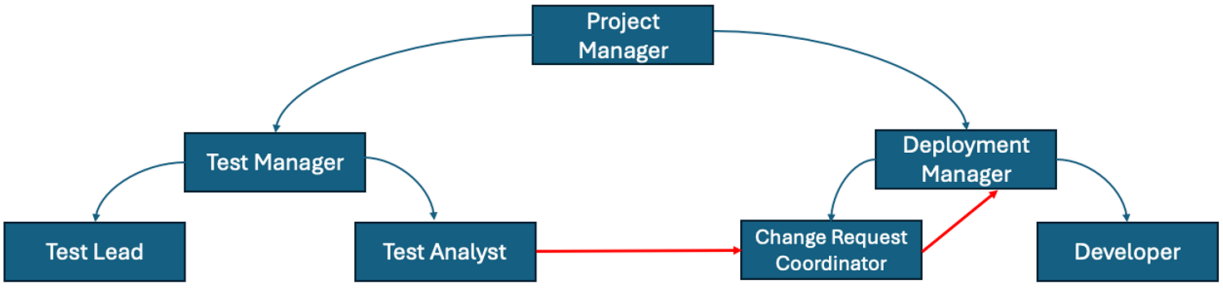


Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Team Dynamic and Career Progression from Test Analyst, to Change Request Coordinator to Deployment Management."

I have worked in the Ministry of Defence Public Sector industry for the past four years, initially joining IBM as Software Tester through the Foundation Apprenticeship program in 2021. Upon completion, I specialised in Workflow Testing and Automation where I was responsible for writing and executing manual test scripts, finding and logging defects, and presenting my findings back to stakeholders through demo's and presentations.

Using my previous experience as a tester helped me succeed early into my role as a Deployment Manager, where I now work closely with the client to ensure that the appropriate Quality Assurance requirements are in place to provide a successful Route to Live delivery process. An example of this would be the use of Runbook reviews after each Dress Rehearsals prior to Production Go Live. These test results are reviewed to ensure that the dress rehearsals orchestrated by the developers have met the needs of the requirements to move onto the next phase of the deployment process. (PMI, 2021, p. 79)

Belbin Assessments

As part of understanding my approach to working within teams, I completed the Belbin Team Roles assessment. My strongest roles were **Implementer (11)** and **Team Worker (10)**, with **Complete Finisher (9)** as a supporting role. As an implementer, I can convert ideas into practical actions. An example of this would be innovating the Change Request process from Outlook to Jira for better accessibility to the wider business. As a team worker, I can confidently use my versatility to complete tasks within a team. As a case in point, using my testing knowledge from my previous role, I can communicate differ perspectives in meetings with stakeholders to give test solutions to deployment problems. With the Complete Finisher, I ensure Quality Assurance is at a high standard, specifically with extensive checks provided to documentation prior to creating the change requests. (Belbin, NA)

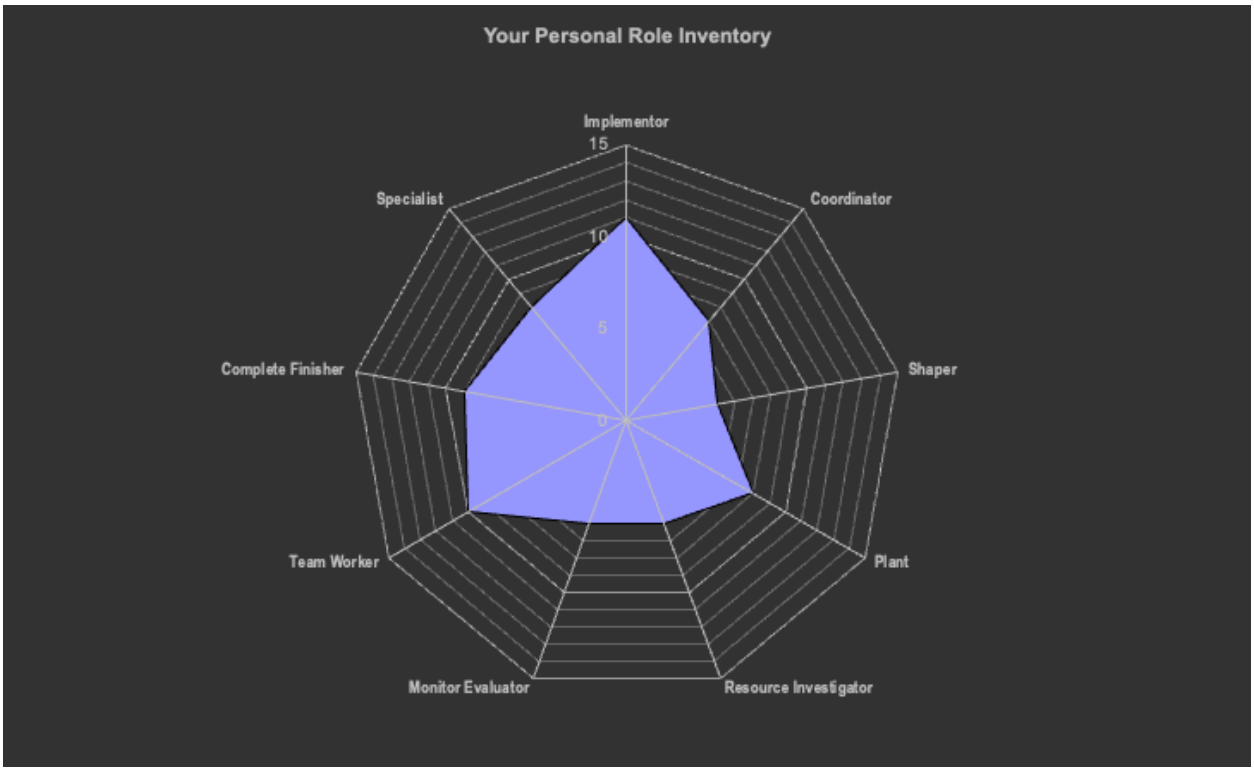


Image from Belbin test from lecture PowerPoint: "My results after taking the Belbin assessment."

High-Performing Teams

Following my Belbin Results, the success I contribute to comes from a high performing team that is built on having a shared understanding. My colleague who supports me in change management also shares the same career progression of having testing experience which allows us to have a shared understanding on providing Quality Assurance to the Route to Live process as discussed in High Performing Project Teams. (PMI ,2021, p 22)

Agile DSUMs

Linking back with working within a High performing team, Integrating Daily Stand Up Meetings (DSUM) has enhanced our collaboration between colleagues to across the different roles and has encourage more diverse ideas. Our calls include testers, architects, software engineers and project managers. As the whole team have busy schedules, integrating this call at the start of the day can provide a

quick and efficient way of understanding on what each participent is focusing on which helps us achieve our tasks easier. (Furman, 2015, p 378)

Kanban board

For Kanban, our team use Jira to track the progress of tasks throughout the business. Using a Kanban Board has enforced prioritisation and rationalises the workload to make sure commitments are made to the tasks that are higher priority. (Ellis, 2020, p 410). We have also found success in improving traceability to defects across boards. This has been crucial as defects and issues are crucial information in our Change Requests. Below is a representation of a Kanban board for Change requests and deployment tasks for the Route to Live process.

Name	Assign	Multi-select	Status	Tags	tag
Untitled			In progress		
CR Route to Live Environment 3			In progress		
Change Request Route to Live Environment 1			Done		
Change Request Route to Live Environment 2			Done		
Untitled			Not started		
Untitled			Not started		
Pre-Prod Change Request			Not started		Approved
Environment 1 Deployment			Not started		Done
Dress Rehearsal 1 Deployment			Not started		Done

Name	Assign	Multi-select	Status	Tags	tag
Dress Rehearsal 2 Deployment			Not started		Approved
Untitled			Not started		
Remote Desktop allocation for Pre-Prod			In progress		In progress
Environment 1 Change Request			Not started		Done
Production Go Live Deployment	R Rio Kandekore		Not started		Not started
Fix Defect RTL	R Rio Kandekore		Not started		Not started
Post Production Defect Fixes			Not started		Backlog

Tuckman's Model

Following the use of this Kanban Model, the below image discusses the Tuckman Model has been evident in resolving a conflict with stakeholders which resulted in an improved process for approving Change Requests. Tuckman (1978)

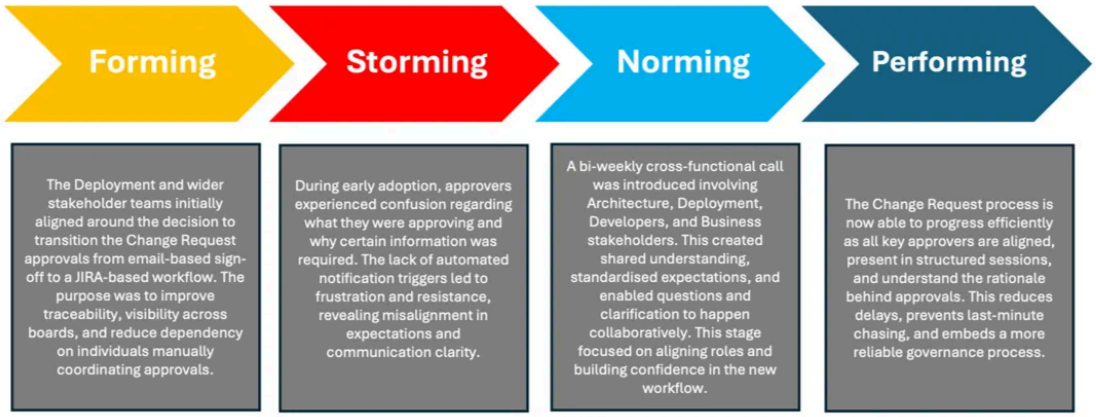


Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Tuckman's Model discussing overcoming conflict with a new Change Request process to obtain approvals."

📝 Project Management Tools and Methodologies

Contractual Agreements

The use of contractual agreements such as a off the job hours requirements, KSBs allow me to have attainable targets to hit each year. As described in (Skills England, 2023) , my degree apprenticeship is split over 4 years with the objective to develop a broad set of skills across the whole Digital and Technology landscape. Following these contractual agreements, this will enable me to deliver the expected deliverables and outcomes that have been addressed in the Success Criteria. (PMI, 2021, p. 69)

PDF from Manchester Metropolitan University: "Contractual Agreement stating my OTJ Hours, start date and end date for my Degree Apprenticeship."

attachment:9da12913-0dc4-4fc0-b67d-036c6928ac4a:Apprenticeship_Agreement_and_Financial_Schedule_-_Rio_Kandekore_at_IBM_.pdf

attachment:96593751-9853-4a8c-976a-2900d238a2b3:ITC_KSB_Themes.pdf

PDF from Manchester Metropolitan University: "KSB Documentation of the Key themes and KSB's for my apprenticeship."

Year 1 and Year 2 Skill Scans

In the image below, I took this initial Skills Scan before I started my first year in order to understand the KSB gaps I had which gave me an overview of the things I needed to work on.

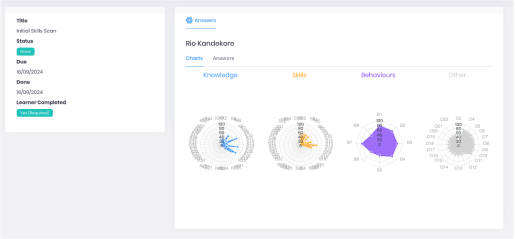
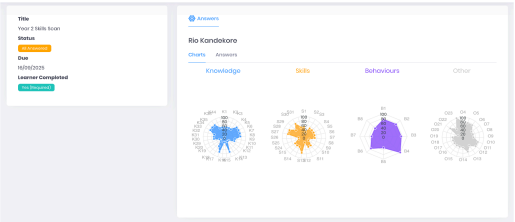


Image from Smart Assessor: "Year 1 Skill Scan."

Following the completion of my first year, I saw an overall improvement in all three areas of the Knowledge, Skills and Behaviours. With successfully completing my first year of university, I have completed Phase 1 within my Project Timeline.



Project Plan

Project Summary	This project outlines my four-year Degree Apprenticeship journey at IBM, structured as a professional development project. It combines academic progression, industry experience, and personal growth to deliver both technical and business outcomes. The project aims to demonstrate the application of project management principles across education, work-based learning, and self-development initiatives.
Success Criteria	Obtain a first from my degree from university Obtain a Distinction from my Apprenticeship at IBM Become a more versatile apprentice (business-minded/technical) Complete portfolio evidence aligned with Knowledge, Skills, and Behaviours (KSBs).
Scope of Work	My scope of work will consist of a blend between hands-on industry experience, University learning and self-development. Events such as networking socials, public speaking and apprenticeship communities.
Key Deliverables	Completion of BSc (Hons) Digital & Technology Solutions degree (First Class target) Completion of IBM Apprenticeship with Distinction Delivery of a personal and professional portfolio demonstrating technical, business, and leadership skills Achievement of AWS and related certifications that align with IBM's vision Successful transition into a technical or hybrid role (e.g., Cloud, Data, or AI) Reflective report showcasing continuous learning, self-awareness, and risk mitigation throughout the apprenticeship lifecycle
Project Timeline	**Estimated Duration: 4 years (42.5 months)** **Phase 1 - September 2024 - September 2025:** Complete First Year of university (Level 4) Move from testing to deployment to open up new opportunities **Phase 2 - September 2025 - September 2026:** Complete Second Year of university Begin to Upskill (Courses, building relationships with seniors) Portfolio work - Meet KSBs themes (Core Concepts) **Phase 3 - September 2026 - September 2027:** Complete Third Year of university Land a technical role within Data Science/DevOps at IBM Portfolio work - Meet KSBs themes (Technical Solutions /Underlying principles, and innovation and response) **Phase 4 - September 2027 - June 2028:** Complete final year of university with a First Grade Complete my Apprenticeship with a Distinction Grade Use new role to diversify EPA Portfolio Portfolio work - Meet KSBs themes (Leading and working together, and Legal ethical landscapes)

Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Project Plan with the Project Summary, Success Criteria, Scope of work, Key deliverables and Project Timeline broken down into 4 phases in order to reach my targets."

Image from Smart Assessor:
“Year 2 Skill Scan.”

Project Name = Digital and Technology Solutions Apprenticeship
Project Start: 16/09/2024
Project end: 31/07/2028
Total Off the Job Training Hours: 991

Q1 = September, October, November
Q2 = December, January, February
Q3 = March, April, May
Q4 = June, July, August

*Include Hours per year

Focus Area	Objective	Start Date	End Date	RAG	Y1 Q1 (01/09/2024–30/11/2024)	Y1 Q2 (01/12/2024–28/02/2025)	Y1 Q3 (01/03/2025–31/05/2025)	Y1 Q4 (01/06/2025–31/08/2025)	Y2 Q1 (01/09/2025–30/11/2025)	Y2 Q2 (01/12/2025–28/02/2026)	Y2 Q3 (01/03/2026–31/05/2026)	Y2 Q4 (01/06/2026–31/08/2026)	Y3 Q1 (01/09/2026–30/11/2026)	Y3 Q2 (01/12/2026–28/02/2027)	Y3 Q3 (01/03/2027–31/05/2027)	Y3 Q4 (01/06/2027–31/08/2027)	Y4 Q1 (01/09/2027–30/11/2027)	Y4 Q2 (01/12/2027–28/02/2028)	Y4 Q3 (01/03/2028–31/05/2028)	Y4 Q4 (01/06/2028–31/08/2028)
Year 1																				
Complete First Year	Complete First Semester with assignments handed in at a timely manner.	30/09/2024	09/04/2025																	
Change role	Moved from testing to deployment to open up new opportunities within IBM.	02/12/2024	20/06/2025																	
Progress into Second Year	Meet all grades needed from all 4 modules to progress into Year 2.	05/05/2025	14/07/2025																	
Year 2																				
Complete Second Year	Complete Second Year with all assignments handed in at a timely manner.	30/09/2025	28/04/2026																	
Become recognised by clients and partners	Become recognised for building trust with our clients at IBM and get feedback to help build portfolio evidence to meet KSB's.	01/09/2026	31/08/2027																	
Upskill in Technical Skills	Begin to Upskill that align with IBM's vision (Courses, building relationships with seniors)	01/09/2025	31/08/2028																	
Complete KSB Themes for Year 2	Portfolio work - Meet KSBs themes (Core Concepts)	30/09/2025	28/04/2026																	
Year 3																				
Complete Third Year	Complete Third Year with all assignments handed in at a timely manner.	29/09/2026	27/04/2027																	
Complete KSB Themes for Year 3	Meet KSBs themes (Technical Solutions /Underlying principles, and innovation and response)	01/09/2026	31/08/2027																	
Land a new technical role	Use skills learnt from previous year to land a new role to expand my knowledge at IBM.	01/09/2026	31/12/2026																	
Year 4																				
Complete KSB Themes for Final Year	Meet KSBs themes (Leading and working together, and Legal ethical landscapes)	28/09/2027	28/02/2028																	
Complete my Final year at university	Complete final year of university with a First Grade	28/09/2027	31/07/2028																	
Complete my apprenticeship	Complete my Apprenticeship with a Distinction Grade	01/03/2028	30/07/2028																	
Progress more into my techical role	Use new role to diversify EPA Portfolio and grow within IBM.	01/09/2027	31/08/2028																	

Image created by Rio Kandekore: “4 Year Gaant Chart based on contracts, KSB’s, personal development and Project Plan.”

👥 Stakeholder Management

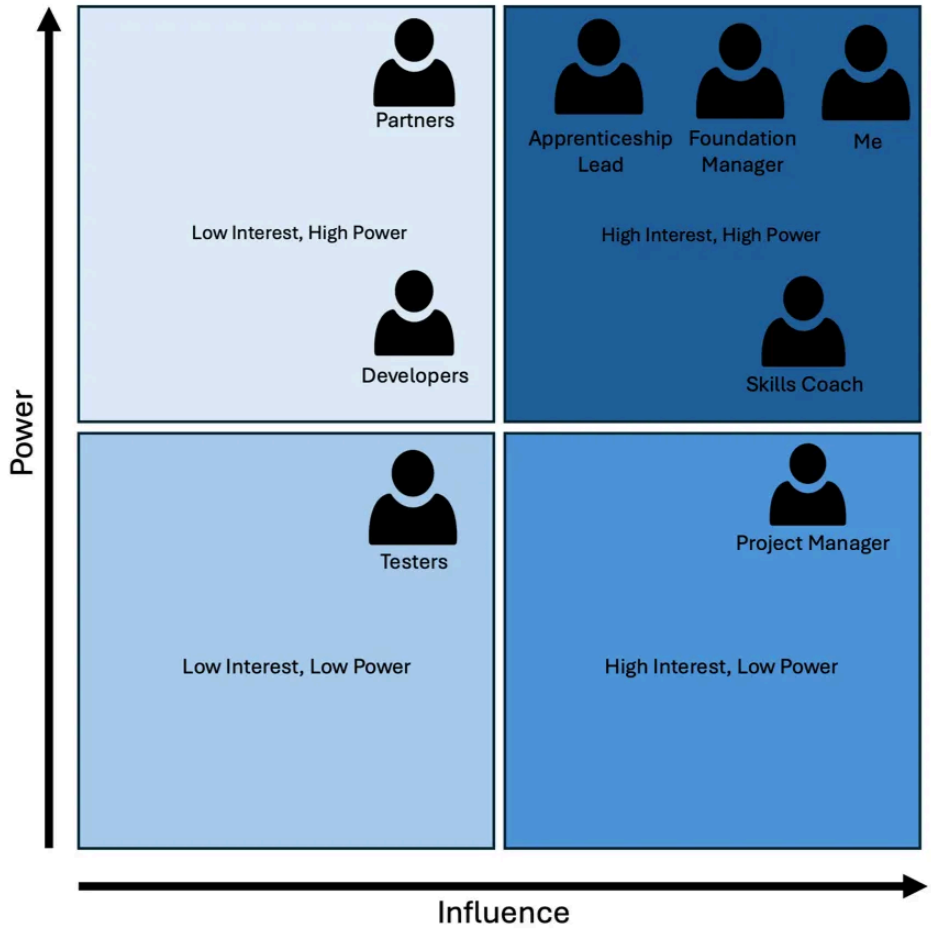


Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Mendelow's Matrix map to determine Stakeholder Power and Influence." (Mendelow, 1981)

The power and influence chart shows the power and interest my chosen stakeholders have in my apprenticeship.

High Power, High interest - Stakeholders who hold the most influence in my apprenticeship

High Power, Low interest - Assign the work that will be used as evidence for my EPA portfolio, however isn't directly involved with my apprenticeship.

Low Power, High interest - These stakeholders do not directly have power but their influence/mentorship can provide growth within my role.

Low Power, Low interest - only require communication if apprenticeship meetings clash with project meetings.

After identifying my stakeholder's power and influence, I created this RACI chart to show stakeholders who are responsible, accountable, consulted, or informed and are associated with the project activities, contractual agreements, and deliverables during my Degree Apprenticeship. (PMI, 2021, pg 189)

RACI Chart	Stakeholders			
Activity	Rio (Apprentice)	Elina (Skills Coach)	Charlotte (Line Manager)	Andy (Project Manager)
Attend University and complete assignments	R	A	C	I
Setting up meetings to monitor progress	A	R	R	I
Complete OTJ Hours, Submit Timesheets and complete Quarterly/ Yearly reviews on time	R	A	A	I
Gather portfolio evidence for EPA	R	A	A	I
Receive feedback from project connections	R	I	I	A
Continue to upskill to stay up to date with IBM's vision	R	I	I	I
R = Responsible A = accountable C = consult I = Inform				

Image created by Rio Kandekore: "RACI chart to demonstrate which stakeholders hold the most influence in my apprenticeship."

Stakeholder Name	Role	Thinking Style	Power	Influence	Communication Plan	Incentives
Kash T	Apprenticeship lead	Practical	High	High	Events Celebrations Apprentice Inititives	My success on the apprenticeship scheme benefits this stakeholder as it builds IBM's apprenticeship reputation, which upholds with IBM winning Apprenticeship of the Year 2024.
Charlotte F	Foundation Manager	Experimental	High	High	Quarterly Reviews Mid Year Reviews End of year Reviews	Better reputation within the role. Making sure I stay ontop of logging my OTJ Hours, Timesheets, and punctuality being on point will help not flag anything up on my manager's side.
Elina A	Skills Coach	Relational	High	High	Quarterly Reviews	My success on the apprenticeship scheme benefits this stakeholder as it builds MMU's apprenticeship reputation.
Andrew H	Project Manager	Experimental	Medium	High	DSUMs 1-2-1 calls End of day calls	Builds trust with workload, helps me to build more evidence for my apprenticeship portfolio.
Brett P	Partner	Practical	High	Medium	Deployment Weekends	Partners benefit business wise when I succeed when I'm able to manage the Route to Live process with ease. This is something I was recognised with an award for.
Gareth B	Developer	Analytical	Medium	Medium	Deployment Standups	Succeeding in my role boosts productivity for the developers, my managerial skills will help manage the Route to Live process for deployment run much smoother.
Saran T	Tester	Experimental	Low	Medium	Testing Standups	Succeeding in my role boosts productivity for the testers my managerial skills will help manage the testing phase run much smoother.

Image created by Rio Kandekore during Week 5 Stakeholder Management Lecture: "Stakeholder Map to demonstrate which stakeholders hold the most influence in my apprenticeship."

(Offord-Woolley, 2024)

⚠️ Risk Management Planning

In my risk assessment plan, I identified my personal well-being and workload as the highest inherent risk to my apprenticeship. As identified in my Mendelow Matrix map, I have the most power and influence for my apprenticeship of all of my stakeholders. Engaging with relevant stakeholders alongside having my Risk Assessment Plan to review and understand my risks will help me mitigate the probability and impacts long term. (PMI 2021, p 54)

Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Risk Matrix to measure the probability and impacts of my risks."

Risk Matrix	Insignificant A	Minor B	Significant C	Major D	Severe E
Almost Certain 5	Medium	High	Very High	Extreme	Extreme
Likely 4	Medium	Medium	High	Very High	Extreme
Moderate 3	Low	Medium	Medium	High	Very High
Unlikely 2	Very Low	Low	Medium	Medium	High
Rare 1	Very Low	Very Low	Low	Medium	Medium

Rio Kandekore - Risk Assessment Plan										
				Inherent Risk				Residual Risk		
Risk	Risk Description	Risk Owner	Probability	Impact	Risk Rating	Mitigation	Mitigation Owner	Residual Probability	Residual Impact	Residual Risk
Time Management	Balancing university deadlines, IBM work, and personal commitments.	Rio	High	Extreme	5E	Implement the use of planning tools such as Notion Calenders, Time-Blocking and prioritise tasks weekly. Communicate early with mentors or line managers about deadlines.	Rio	Low	Medium	2C
Skill Gap/ Knowledge	Not keeping up with IBM's vision with Cloud, Data and AI for future roles and opportunities.	Rio	Low	High	3D	Put aside 30 minutes a day to contribute to any external learning to ensure I build my knowledge. This also ties in with making sure I don't burnout.	Rio	Low	Medium	2D
Data Security and compliant risks	Handling confidential client data during projects could risk breaches or non-compliance if not managed correctly.	Rio	Medium	Extreme	4E	Follow IBM data governance courses, use secure systems, and never store client data locally.	Rio	Low	High	2B
Personal Wellbeing and Workload	Managing multiple responsibilities (university, IBM projects, side learning) can cause burnout or reduced performance.	Rio	High	Extreme	5E	Maintain healthy routines such as exercise, sleep and nutrition. Using MMU wellbeing support if needed, and discuss workload balance with managers or mentors if I begin to struggle.	Rio	Low	Medium	2C
Miscommunication bewteen stakeholders	Miscommunication bewteen stakeholders with things such as OTJ hours, Timesheets and issues on my project could cause issues.	Rio	Medium	Very High	4D	Making sure that if there is an issue to directly consult with my stakeholders as soon as possible. This also helps with maintaining a great reputation.	Rio	Low	Medium	2C

Image created by Rio Kandekore: "My results after taking the Belbin assessment."

🪞 Reflection (Gibbs' Reflective Cycle)

Description

After moving to Manchester for university, I struggled to get used to living on my own, starting university and adjusting to my new role. I went from contributing to food shopping at my moms house to paying rent with utilities, as well as making sure I was maintaining a clean space along with cooking. Before moving, I was a young carer for my older brother in Birmingham so there was an element of guilt when I moved out as I couldn't be present to help my mom.

Feelings

I found this change extremely difficult to the point where I burnt out. Tasks such as getting out of bed, cooking and cleaning felt like massive challenges. Failing one of my assignments also increased my anxiety when it came to assignments and exams. I turned to services such as the university counselling for external help. Initially, I felt quite uncomfortable speaking to my Skills Coach , however she was very welcoming which related to their relational thinking style from my stakeholder map. I also felt it was also important to communicate the reason why my performance such as logging my OTJ hours was behind.

Evaluation and Analysis

While my independence, professional performance, and networking improved, my lack of routine and time management negatively impacted my university work. It's also altered my thinking in regards to assuming that university and my apprenticeship work were two separate things, whereas I came to realise was that they both come hand in hand together. So much focus went into focusing on my job role as a change management coordinator rather than trying to balance both. Although I earned my promotion to my current role as a deployment manager, I felt disappointed with my university performance.

Conclusion

From this experience, I became more independent in myself and I understand what having an unorganised lifestyle looks like. This experience has taught me the importance of setting boundaries and taking care of my well-being. On a personal note, I invested in books and online material to become more financially literate which helped me handle my bills better. I also came out of my comfort zone by attend networking events as well as meeting other apprentices across different industries which has broadened my network. In conclusion, going through this

personal journey of learning how crucial it is to look after my well-being during my apprenticeship journey is crucial in achieving success in both university and project work.

Action Plan

The biggest priority will be focusing on my personal well-being. Maintaining a healthy routine which includes regular exercise, consistent sleep and balanced nutrition is crucial and with this in place, my body is in a better place to handle higher workloads and stressful moments. As mentioned in my Risk Management table, I included time management in my inherent risks. Focusing on mitigating these risks also ties in with managing workload and stress. I've so far implemented timeblocking to delegate my daily tasks much better. Creating the project plan and gaant chart has help me have a direct path in knowing what I want to achieve in my degree apprenticeship. To continue with this momentum, I will make it paramount to regularly review my diagrams and communicate my progress to my stakeholders.

📚 References (15 in-text citations used from 12 Resources)

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